

26

Joseph

The favored son sold into slavery, who rose to rule Egypt and forgave the brothers who betrayed him.

Joseph was the elder son of Jacob and Rachel, and his father's favorite. His brothers hated him for it and sold him to traders bound for Egypt. There he was falsely accused and spent years in prison, yet Genesis says, "the LORD was with Joseph." At thirty he interpreted Pharaoh's dreams and was made ruler over all Egypt. When his brothers came to buy grain, he tested them, then forgave them and kept Jacob's whole family alive. His life shows God working through betrayal to save many people.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Yoseph</i> , "may he add"; Egyptian Zaphnathpaaneah
Family	Son of Jacob and Rachel; full brother of Benjamin
Wife and sons	Asenath; Manasseh and Ephraim (Genesis 41:45, 50–52)
Key places	Dothan; Potiphar's house; the prison; Pharaoh's court; Goshen
Key people	Jacob, Reuben, Judah, Benjamin, Potiphar, Pharaoh
Lifespan	110 years (Genesis 50:26)
Main passages	Genesis 30:22–24; 37; 39–50
New Testament	John 4:5; Acts 7:9–18; Hebrews 11:21–22

"But as for you, ye thought evil against me; but God meant it unto good, to bring to pass, as it is this day, to save much people alive."

Genesis 50:20, KJV

The life of Joseph

Dates are approximate (BC), following the traditional chronology from 1 Kings 6:1. Many scholars place the patriarchs c. 2000–1700 BC. Joseph's Pharaoh is not named.

- | | |
|--------------------------------------|---|
| c. 1915 BC
<i>In Haran</i> | ● Born to Rachel
Rachel bears her first son and names him Joseph: "The LORD shall add to me another son." <i>Genesis 30:22–24</i> |
| c. 1898 BC
<i>Age 17</i> | ● The coat and the dreams
Jacob gives Joseph a coat of many colours. Joseph dreams that his family bows to him, and his brothers hate him. <i>Genesis 37:2–11</i> |
| c. 1898 BC
<i>Age 17</i> | ● Sold into Egypt
At Dothan the brothers sell him for twenty pieces of silver and let Jacob believe a beast killed him. <i>Genesis 37:12–36</i> |
| Age 17 to 30 | ● Slave and prisoner
Falsely accused by Potiphar's wife, he is imprisoned and interprets the butler's and baker's dreams. <i>Genesis 39:1–40:23</i> |
| c. 1885 BC
<i>Age 30</i> | ● Ruler of Egypt
Joseph explains Pharaoh's dreams of plenty and famine and is set over all the land. <i>Genesis 41:1–49</i> |
| The famine years | ● His brothers bow
Ten brothers come to buy grain and do not know him. He tests them and demands Benjamin. <i>Genesis 42:1–44:34</i> |
| c. 1876 BC
<i>Age 39</i> | ● Reveals himself
"I am Joseph." He forgives his brothers and settles Jacob's family in Goshen. <i>Genesis 45:1–46:30</i> |
| c. 1805 BC
<i>Age 110</i> | ● Dies in Egypt
He makes Israel promise to carry his bones to Canaan and is embalmed. <i>Genesis 50:22–26</i> |

Key activities

Joseph's famine policy made Egyptians Pharaoh's servants (Genesis 47:13–26). Some see wise leadership; others a harsh deal. Genesis gives no comment.

-
- I Told his dreams.** He shared dreams of his family bowing to him, which fed his brothers' envy. *Genesis 37:5–11*

 - 2 Worked faithfully as a slave.** Potiphar put him in charge of everything, and the LORD blessed the house. *Genesis 39:2–6*

 - 3 Refused temptation.** "How then can I do this great wickedness, and sin against God?" He ran away. *Genesis 39:7–12*

 - 4 Served in prison.** The keeper of the prison trusted him with all the prisoners. *Genesis 39:20–23*

 - 5 Gave God the credit.** He told Pharaoh, "It is not in me: God shall give Pharaoh an answer of peace." *Genesis 41:14–16, 25–32*

 - 6 Planned for the famine.** He gathered a fifth of the harvest in the good years and stored grain in the cities. *Genesis 41:34–36, 47–49*

 - 7 Named his sons in faith.** Manasseh meant God had made him forget his toil; Ephraim meant God had made him fruitful in his affliction. *Genesis 41:50–52*

 - 8 Tested his brothers.** He held Simeon, demanded Benjamin, and hid his cup in Benjamin's sack to see if they had changed. *Genesis 42:18–44:17*

 - 9 Forgave and wept.** He told them, "God did send me before you to preserve life." *Genesis 45:1–15*

 - 10 Cared for his family.** He settled Jacob's household in Goshen and fed them through the famine. *Genesis 47:11–12*

 - 11 Brought his sons to be blessed.** Jacob adopted Ephraim and Manasseh as his own and put the younger first. *Genesis 48:1–20*

 - 12 Looked ahead in faith.** Dying, he said, "God will surely visit you," and asked that his bones go to Canaan. *Genesis 50:24–25*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Joseph.

Old Testament

Genesis 37–50	The main account
Exodus 1:8	A new king arises "which knew not Joseph"
Exodus 13:19; Joshua 24:32	His bones carried out and buried at Shechem
Psalms 105:16–22	God "sent a man before them, even Joseph"
Echo: Daniel 2:46–48	Another dream-reader raised high by a foreign king

New Testament

John 4:5	Sychar, near the ground Jacob gave Joseph
Acts 7:9–16	Stephen: sold by envious brothers, "but God was with him"
Hebrews 11:22	By faith he gave commandment concerning his bones
Echo: Romans 8:28	Many Christians see Joseph as a picture of Christ

For discussion

1. *Observe:* Where was the LORD with Joseph in Genesis 39:2–3 and 21–23, and what did that look like?
2. *Understand:* "Ye thought evil against me; but God meant it unto good" (Genesis 50:20). How can both be true?
3. *Apply:* Joseph ran from temptation when no one would have known. What helps you do right when unseen?
4. *Apply:* Joseph forgave those who hurt him most. Is there someone you need to forgive?